ACT / STRATEGY / FREE GUIDE

ACT Pacing & Test-Taking Strategies

Build a pacing plan that protects your time and helps you recover from hard questions.

By TestPrepUnraveled • Updated September 12, 2026 • 5 min read

Practice the right format

Use current official practice materials for your test administration. The ACT has changed, so avoid building your pacing around an old question count or time limit. Follow the timing printed on the matching official practice test.

Learn your own bottlenecks

Record where you spend time without making progress. A math setup, rereading a passage, and checking grammar may require different adjustments. Work on the recurring bottleneck rather than trying to rush every question.

Use a deliberate skip decision

When stuck, eliminate what you can, choose your best answer, and continue. If your test format permits review within the current section, return before time ends. On paper, keep the answer sheet aligned when moving between questions.

Review the decision, not just the score

After practice, distinguish questions you could solve with a better strategy from questions needing more content study. Track whether your pacing changes leave enough time for questions you know how to answer.

YOUR DESK-SIDE REFERENCE

Quick reference

Situation	Useful response	Practice habit
No clear next step	Choose your best answer and move	Notice repeated unproductive steps
Two options remain	Find the precise difference	Explain why one is unsupported
Calculator result looks wrong	Check setup and units	Estimate before computing
Paper answer sheet	Verify the question number	Check alignment regularly

Original worked example

You keep rereading an entire passage for each detail question. What could help?

Build a short paragraph map on the first read. Return to the relevant area for each detail and read enough surrounding context to preserve meaning.

A tip worth keeping

Do a complete review after timed practice. Speed without feedback can reinforce the same mistakes.

Your quick checklist

- Identify the exact task before working.
- Show the reasoning, not just the answer.
- Review the mistake and try a new example.

PUT IT INTO PRACTICE

Try it yourself

These original questions were written for this guide. Try each one before reading the answer key.

1. Should you use an old practice test’s timing for a newer format?

2. What is a useful first check when an answer has the wrong scale?

3. Why review questions you guessed correctly?

Answers & explanations

1. No. Use official materials and timing matching your administration.

2. Check units and estimate the expected size before repeating the arithmetic.

3. A correct guess can hide a skill gap. Explain the reasoning so you can reproduce it.

Keep your prep current

Check your test provider for current rules and format details. These are independent sample guides and contain no official test questions.

Official ACT format updates

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